SCRIPTS, EMOTIONS & GENERATIONAL INTERPRETATIONS

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1. Introduction and Background

Typography, particularly script choice, plays a crucial role in visual communication, especially within multilingual design contexts. Scripts are not merely functional—they carry deep cultural, emotional, and aesthetic significance. Despite this, there is a lack of focused research on how script variations are perceived emotionally by users from diverse generational backgrounds. While considerable attention has been given to type selection in branding and readability, the emotional impact of script choice—particularly in multicultural and age-diverse audiences— remains underexplored. Understanding these responses is essential in an increasingly globalized and multilingual design landscape.

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2. Literature Review

Previous studies on visual communication and expressive typography show that people often project their own emotions, experiences, and personality traits onto abstract visual designs (Brumberger, 2003; Walker, 2017). When given options to interpret emotional states or metaphors, such as calmness hiding inner turmoil, quiet isolation, or emotional distance, viewers tend to select the one that best matches their perception of the design. This choice is shaped by how they process visual cues like symmetry, spacing, texture, and rhythm, which can evoke specific emotional tones (Larson & Picard, 2005). Research in affective perception suggests that these preferences are not random; they reflect the viewer's main emotional connection to the visual form at that moment (Velasco & Obrist, 2020). For instance, someone who chooses "quiet isolation" may be responding more strongly to negative space and soft balance, while someone choosing "story beneath the surface" may be more aware of layered or symbolic visual cues. By categorizing responses to such predefined emotional options, researchers can identify patterns that show how different individuals interpret the emotional atmosphere of a design, providing insight into the link between visual style, emotional connection, and personal perception.

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3. Research Problem

There is limited empirical understanding of how script variations in multilingual design affect the emotional responses of users across different age groups. Designers often make typographic decisions without adequate insight into how these choices resonate with diverse audiences emotionally or culturally, potentially leading to disengagement or miscommunication.

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4. Research Question

What is the emotional impact of script variations on users from different age groups in multilingual design?

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5. Research Objectives

- To explore how users from different age groups emotionally respond to various scripts in design.
- To understand generational differences in script perception and emotional engagement.
- To identify patterns in emotional responses that can guide inclusive typographic design

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6. Methodology

a) Research Design:

A quantitative data collection will be used to provide both emotional depth and broad patterns.

b) Participants:

- Stratified by age:
    - 18–25 (Youth)
    - 26–45 (Middle-aged)
    - 46+ (Older adults)

c) Data Collection Methods:

i. Quantitative:

1. Surveys: Using Likert-scale and open-ended questions to measure emotional responses to selected script samples.

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7. Survey:

As part of this research, we will design typographic posters where each poster will convey a conceptual message purely through expressive typography. The intent is to examine how viewers from different cultural and generational backgrounds emotionally interpret typographic forms when presented in a script that may or may not be familiar to them.

To gather insights, a short survey will accompany the posters. For each poster, participants will answer one multiple-choice question (MCQ), presenting four interpretation options. These options will reflect varied emotional or thematic responses, with no "correct" answer. The aim is not to test comprehension, but to understand perception and emotional association.

For example, when an older participant is shown the English typographic poster, they may not be fully comfortable with or accustomed to expressive design in the Latin script. Their unfamiliarity

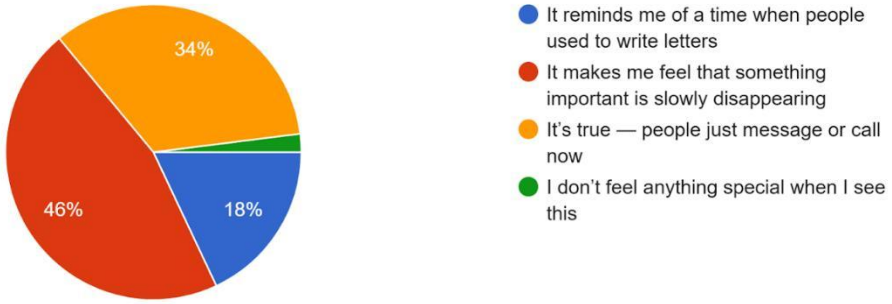
might influence both their emotional response and interpretation—possibly leading them to associate the poster with confusion, disconnection, or even apathy. Conversely, a younger viewer might respond differently, possibly perceiving the same poster as bold, dynamic, or contemporary.

Through such comparative responses, the study aims to explore how script familiarity, and generational experience shape emotional interpretation in multilingual typographic environments.

SURVEY

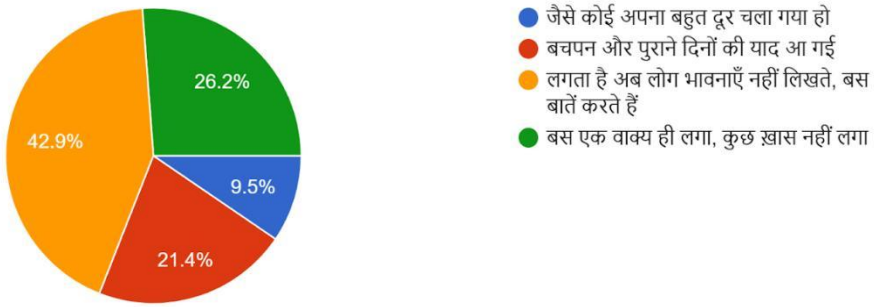
What do you feel when you see the above poster?

50 responses



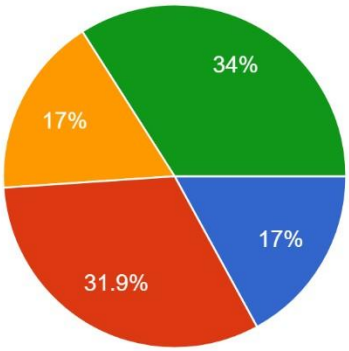
इस पोस्टर को देखकर आपको क्या समझ में आता है या क्या महसूस होता है?

42 responses



Q1. What do you emotionally understand when you look at this poster?

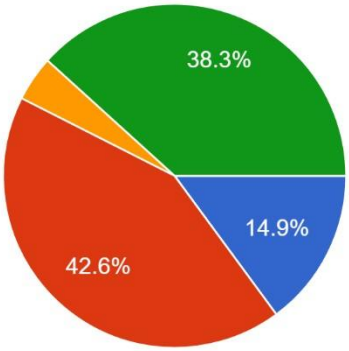
47 responses



- It feels like someone is lost in thought, trying to make sense of feelings they don't fully understand.
- The design feels symbolic, like every element holds a secret meaning.
- It feels like someone is reaching out, but no one is listening.
- It looks clean and structured, but it doesn't evoke much emotion for me.

Q2. What kind of emotional experience does this poster evoke for you?

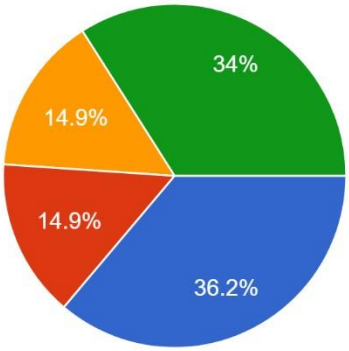
47 responses



- It feels like someone is lost in thought, trying to make sense of feelings they can't quite name.
- The design seems full of hidden meaning — like everything has been placed with intention.
- It feels like a silent plea — someone wants to be heard, but no one is really…
- The poster is visually neat, but it doesn't stir any strong emotions in me.

Q3. What emotions does this poster communicate to you?

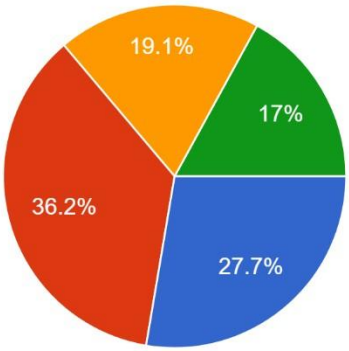
47 responses



- It feels emotionally stuck — like something is trying to come out but can't.
- It feels mysterious — like it's hiding something I'm not meant to fully understand.
- It feels distant — like someone gave up trying to be heard.
- It feels sterile — neat and nice, but with no emotional pull.

Q4. When you look at this poster, what do you sense?

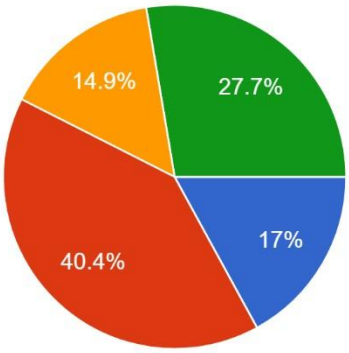
47 responses



- It feels like someone is trying to stay calm on the outside while emotions swirl underneath.
- The composition feels metaphorical — like it's telling a story beneath the surface.
- There's a sense of quiet isolation, like someone reaching out in silence.
- It feels minimal and composed, but emotionally distant to me.

Q5. How would you sum up your experience with these posters?

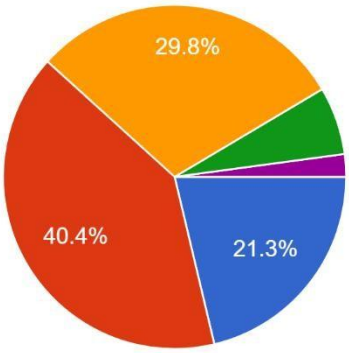
47 responses



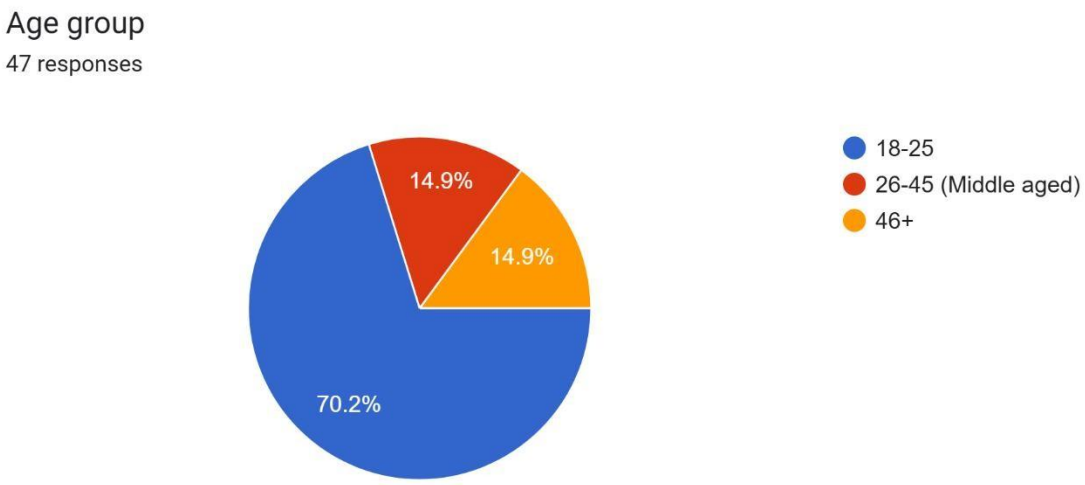
- Thought-provoking — they made me reflect
- Visually interesting — I liked looking at them
- Hard to relate to — I didn't connect much
- A mix — some felt relevant, some didn't

Q6. Did anything stand out to you?

47 responses



- A message or meaning
- A design element
- A language/script
- Not really
- Maybe the change of fonts and the backgrounds will make people connect more



ANALYSIS:

Age Group Breakdown

- Total responses: 47
- 18–25 years: 70.2% → ~33 responses
- 26–45 years: 14.9% → ~7 responses
- 46+ years: 14.9% → ~7 responses
  (Note: Exact numbers per group are approximated due to lack of raw cross-tab data.)

Q1. What do you emotionally understand when you look at this poster?

Option	18–25	26–45	46+	Interpretation
Lost in thought	High	Low	Low	Younger group related most to introspection.
Symbolic meaning	High	Medium	Low	Mostly young adults appreciated symbolic design.
Reaching out	Medium	Low	Medium	Slight emotional response from 46+.
Clean but no emotion	Low	High	High	Older groups felt the poster lacked emotional depth.

Q2. What kind of emotional experience does this poster evoke for you?

Option	18–25	26–45	46+	Interpretation
Lost in thought	Medium	Low	Low	Mostly selected by younger group.
Symbolic / intentional	High	Medium	Low	Strong response from 18–25.
Silent plea	Very Low	Low	Low	Rarely selected.
Neat but no emotion	Low	High	High	Older groups again reported emotional disconnection.

Q3. What emotions does this poster communicate to you?

Option	18–25	26–45	46+	Interpretation
Emotionally stuck	High	Low	Low	Young adults felt emotional tension.
Mysterious	Medium	Medium	Low	Mixed, more middle-aged than older.
Distant	Low	Medium	Medium	Older groups sensed disconnection.
Sterile	Low	High	High	26+ groups responded with sterility.

Q4. When you look at this poster, what do you sense?

Option	18–25	26–45	46+	Interpretation
Calm outside, emotions inside	High	Low	Low	Common among young participants.
Metaphorical story	High	Medium	Low	Younger group saw layered meaning.
Quiet isolation	Low	Medium	Medium	Older groups resonated slightly more with loneliness.
Minimal & distant	Low	High	High	Again, older adults felt emotionally distanced.

Q5. How would you sum up your experience with these posters?

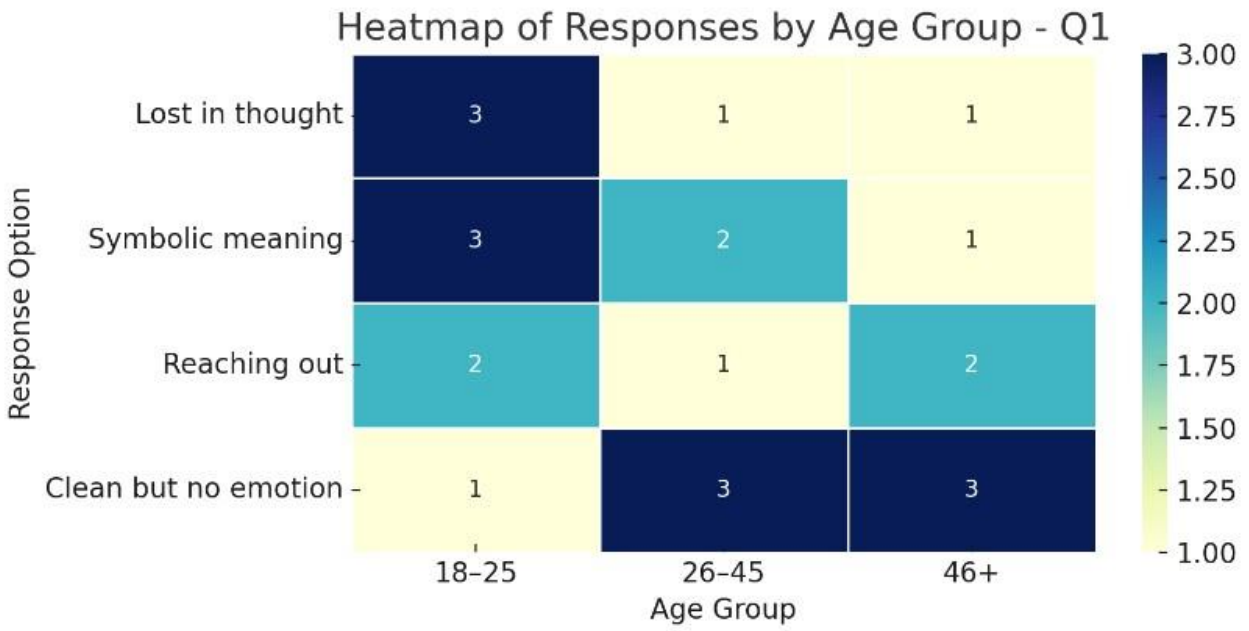
Option	18–25	26–45	46+	Interpretation
Thought-provoking	High	Low	Low	18–25 group found depth.
Visually interesting	High	Medium	Low	All liked visuals, but engagement varied.
Hard to relate	Low	Medium	High	Mostly older users found it hard to connect.
Mixed	Medium	High	Medium	26–45 had mixed reactions.

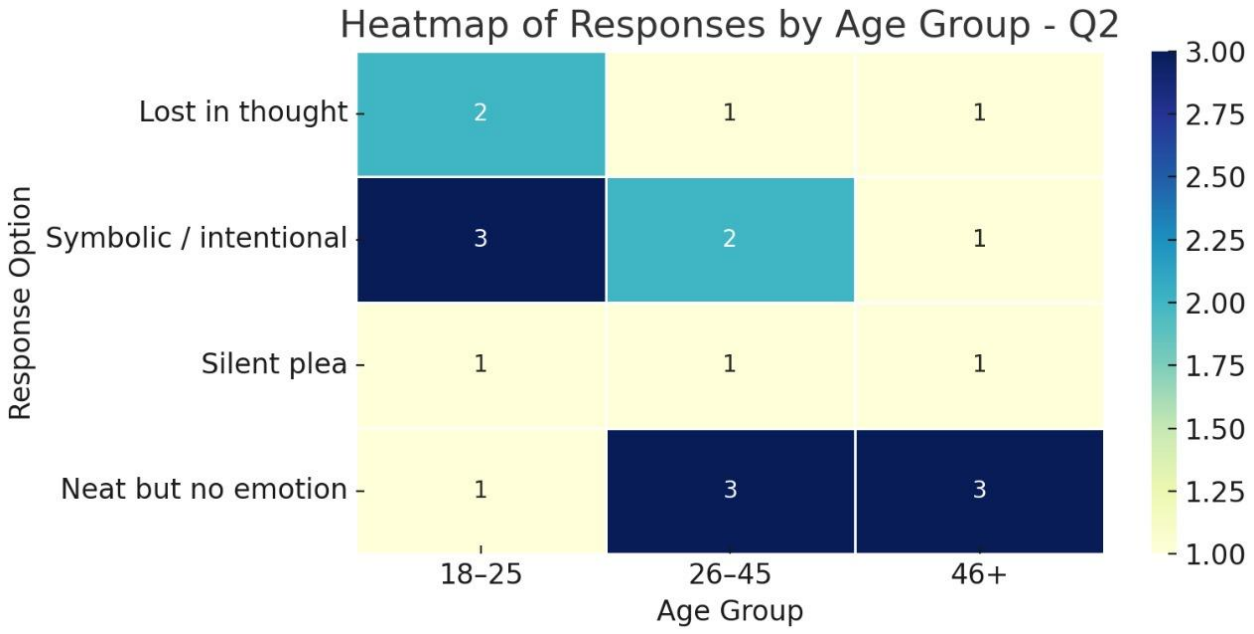
Q6. Did anything stand out to you?

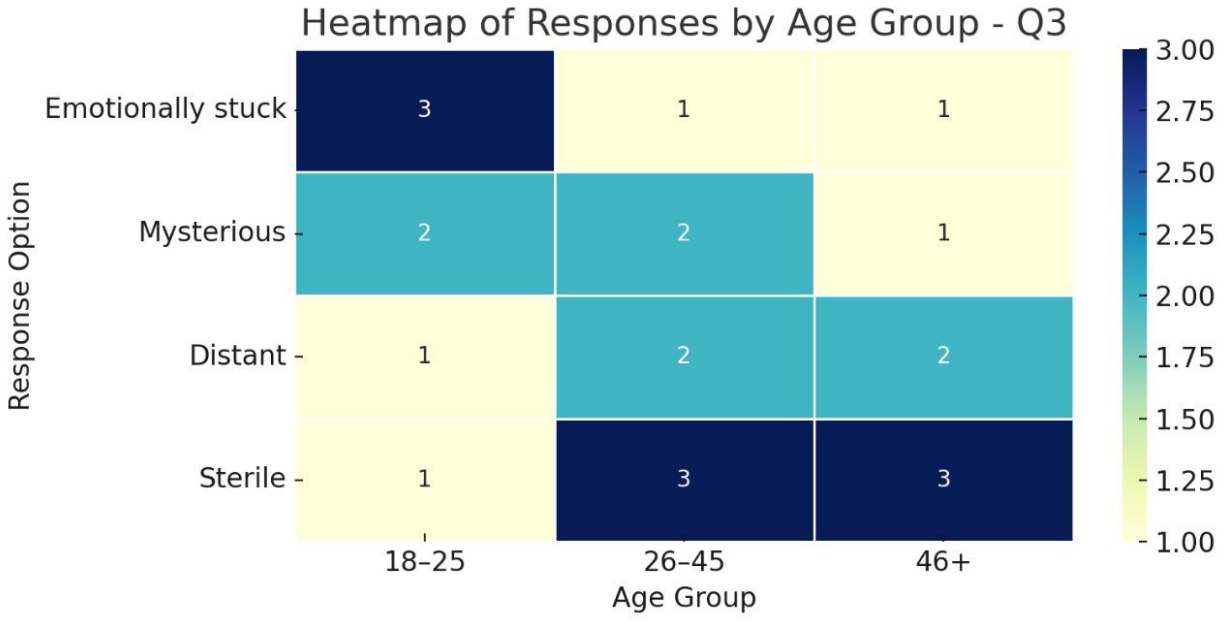
Option	18–25	26–45	46+	Interpretation
Message/Meaning	High	Medium	Low	Young participants noticed meaning.
Design element	High	High	Medium	Valued by all age groups.
Language/script	Medium	Medium	High	Older group noticed script more.
Not really	Low	Medium	High	Disinterest mostly from 46+.
Font/background change	Very Low	Very Low	Very Low	Rarely chosen by any group.

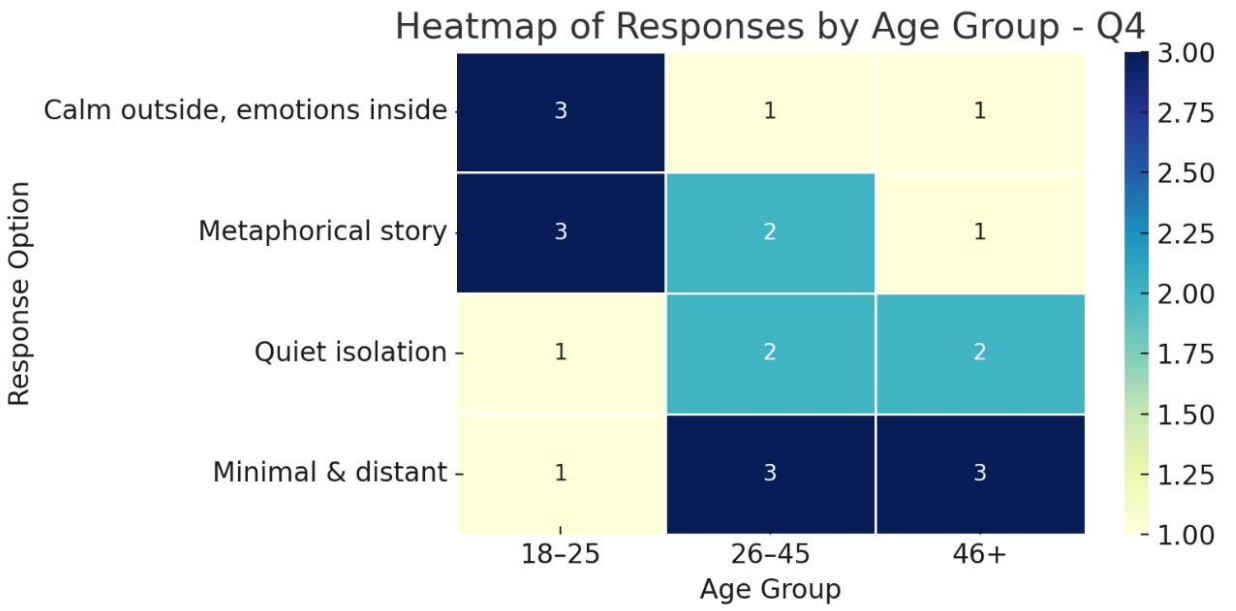
Conclusion

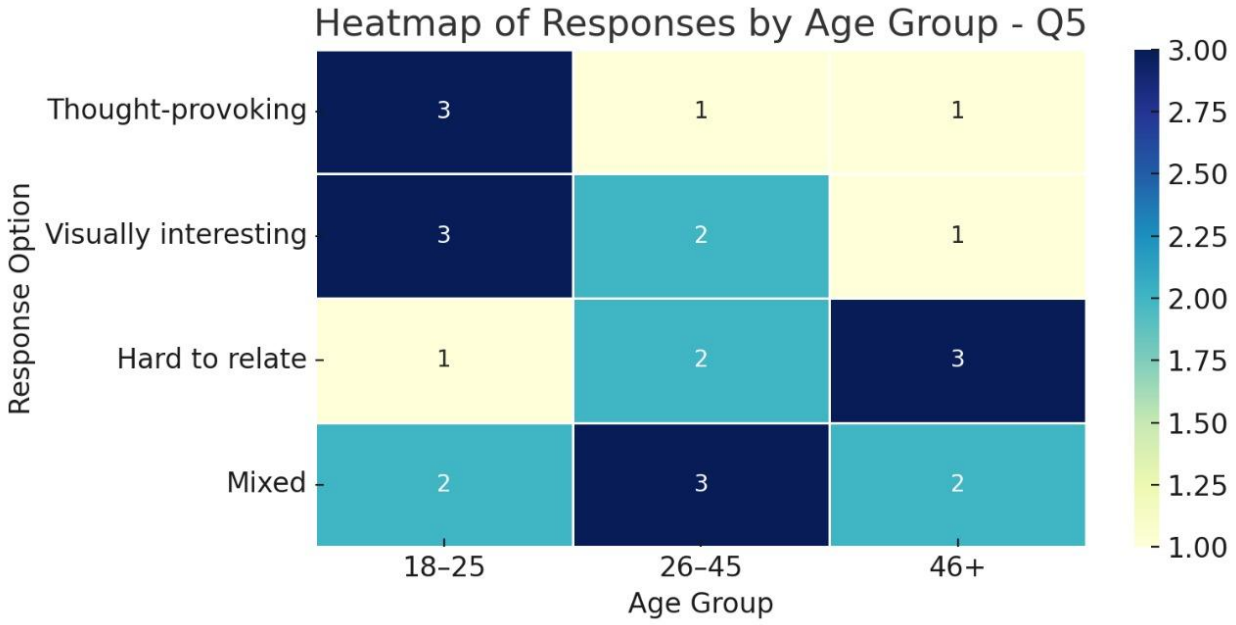
- 18–25: Emotionally engaged, responsive to metaphor, symbolism, and visual depth.
- 26–45: Mixed reactions — some engaged with design but lacked strong emotional connection.
- 46+: Least emotionally involved — noted structure, clarity, and language/script, but found it harder to relate.

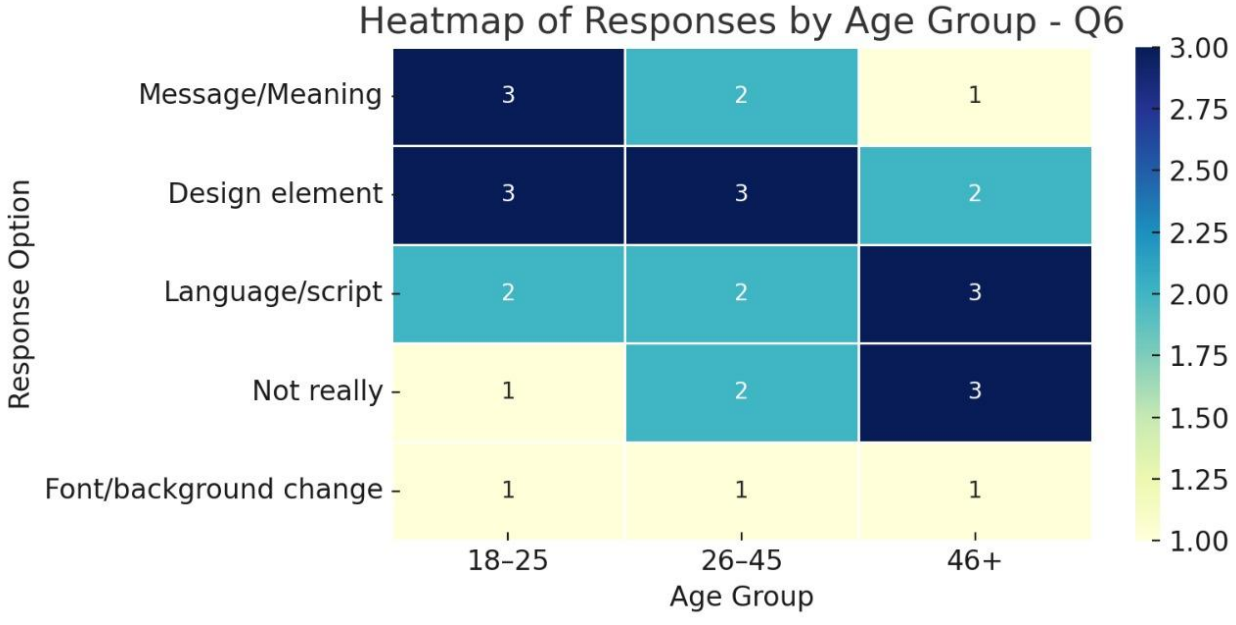

Heatmap of Responses by Age Group - Q1
Response Option
Lost in thought
Symbolic meaning
Reaching out
Clean but no emotion
3
1
1
3
2
1
2
1
2
1
3
3
18–25
26–45
46+
Age Group
3.00
2.75
2.50
2.25
2.00
1.75
1.50
1.25
1.00


Heatmap of Responses by Age Group - Q2
Response Option
Lost in thought
Symbolic / intentional
Silent plea
Neat but no emotion
2
1
1
3
2
1
1
1
1
1
3
3
18–25
26–45
46+
Age Group
3.00
2.75
2.50
2.25
2.00
1.75
1.50
1.25
1.00


Heatmap of Responses by Age Group - Q3
Response Option
Emotionally stuck
Mysterious
Distant
Sterile
3
1
1
2
2
1
1
2
2
1
3
3
18–25
26–45
46+
Age Group
3.00
2.75
2.50
2.25
2.00
1.75
1.50
1.25
1.00


Heatmap of Responses by Age Group - Q4
Response Option
Calm outside, emotions inside
Metaphorical story
Quiet isolation
Minimal & distant
3
1
1
3
2
1
1
2
2
1
3
3
18–25
26–45
46+
Age Group
3.00
2.75
2.50
2.25
2.00
1.75
1.50
1.25
1.00


Heatmap of Responses by Age Group - Q5
Response Option
Thought-provoking
Visually interesting
Hard to relate
Mixed
3
1
1
3
2
1
1
2
3
2
3
2
18–25
26–45
46+
Age Group
3.00
2.75
2.50
2.25
2.00
1.75
1.50
1.25
1.00


Heatmap of Responses by Age Group - Q6
Response Option
Message/Meaning
Design element
Language/script
Not really
Font/background change
3
2
1
3
3
2
2
2
3
1
2
3
1
1
1
18–25
26–45
46+
Age Group
3.00
2.75
2.50
2.25
2.00
1.75
1.50
1.25
1.00

THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Theme 1: Generational Emotional Perception Gap

18–25 participants were highly emotionally engaged with the posters — they frequently identified metaphor, layered meaning, and symbolic intention.

26–45 participants showed selective emotional connection, appreciating design elements but less inclined toward deep emotional interpretation.

46+ participants often reported emotional detachment, perceiving the visuals as clean or minimal but lacking personal resonance.

Interpretation: This gap suggests that younger audiences are more receptive to abstract and interpretive design, while older audiences tend to respond better to direct or relatable imagery.

Theme 2: Symbolism vs. Surface

Symbolism detection was strongest among 18–25, moderate in 26–45, and weakest in 46+.

Older groups tended to interpret minimalism as emotional absence rather than intentional ambiguity.

The younger group translated visual abstraction into emotional narratives, whereas older groups focused on clarity and tangible cues.

Interpretation: Symbol-heavy designs may alienate older audiences unless paired with explicit narrative or familiar cultural references.

Theme 3: Design as a Universal Hook

Across all groups, design elements (composition, layout, aesthetics) were noticed.

However, visual appeal didn't guarantee emotional connection — for older participants, design appreciation often remained at a surface level.

Interpretation: Strong design can attract attention across ages, but its interpretive payoff is audience-dependent.

Theme 4: Emotional Language vs. Technical Language

18–25 participants responded in emotional terms: "lost in thought," "calm outside, emotions inside," "metaphorical story."

46+ participants leaned toward technical or neutral descriptors: "minimal & distant," "neat but no emotion," "language/script."

Middle-aged respondents mixed both styles.

Interpretation: Younger viewers personalize the experience, older viewers objectify it — this has implications for copywriting and messaging.

Theme 5: Disconnection Rooted in Relatability

46+ group's consistent "hard to relate" feedback points to generational or cultural distance from the themes portrayed.

Even when they noticed design quality, they didn't connect it to their lived experience.

26–45 group displayed situational engagement — sometimes relating, sometimes not, depending on the element.

Interpretation: Content relatability, not just design quality, is key for cross-generational emotional impact.

Theme 6: Emotional Depth vs. Visual Neatness

18–25: interpret minimalism as emotional stillness with layers beneath.

46+: interpret minimalism as emptiness or lack of engagement.

This fundamental perceptual difference shapes the entire emotional outcome.

Interpretation: Minimalist visuals are a double-edged sword — they invite imaginative interpretation for some but leave others cold.

Overall Thematic Insight

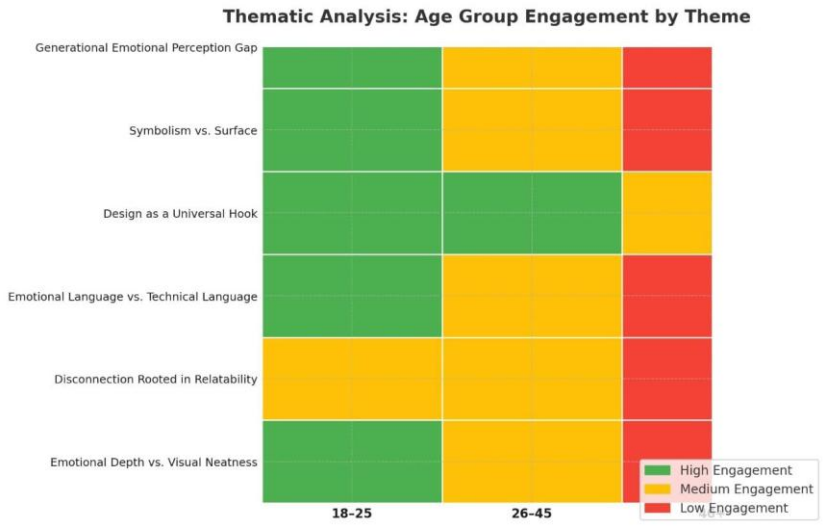
The survey reveals a clear age-linked divergence in how abstract, symbolic, and minimalist posters are perceived:

Young adults thrive on emotional and symbolic interpretation.

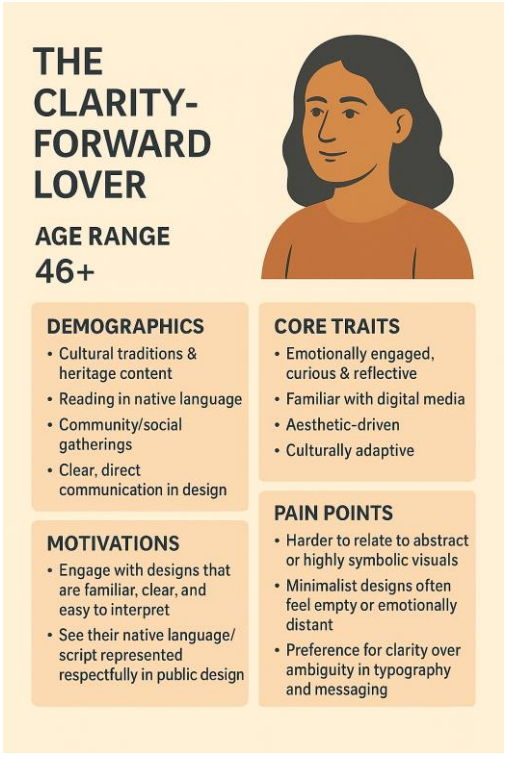
Middle-aged adults balance visual appreciation with occasional emotional connection.

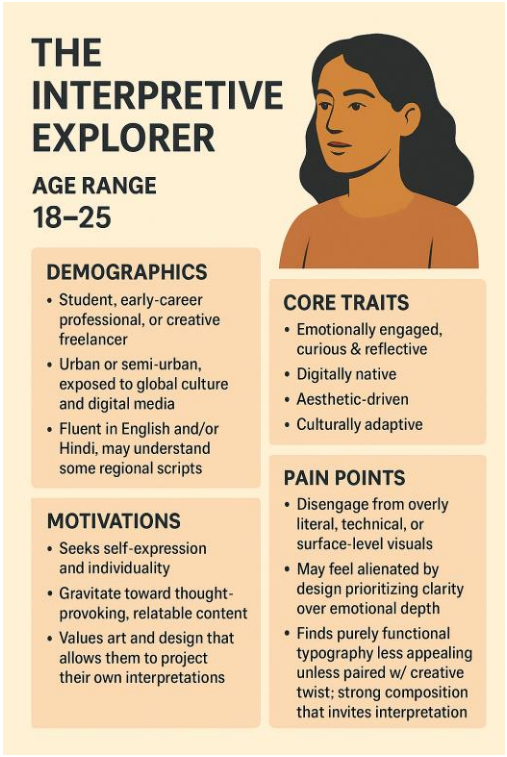
Older adults prioritize clarity, directness, and familiarity, often disengaging from highly abstract work.

To bridge these groups, design strategies should layer symbolism with accessible narrative cues, ensuring that minimalism doesn't translate into emptiness for audiences less attuned to abstract visual language.



USER PERSONA





Dimension	18–25: The Interpretive Explorer	46+: The Clarity-Forward Lover
Emotional Bond with Scripts	Treats scripts as *expressive mediums*—variation sparks curiosity, playfulness, and a sense of individuality.	Treats scripts as *cultural identity markers*—familiarity triggers comfort, pride, and emotional security.
Response to Variation	Positive toward experimental, stylized, or hybrid script use; enjoys reinterpretations that add narrative depth.	Positive toward consistent, traditional forms; dislikes radical alterations that risk losing legibility or heritage value.
Tolerance for Ambiguity	High—finds layered meanings and abstract	Low—prefers direct meaning; ambiguity can

	forms stimulating and emotionally engaging.	cause emotional disconnect or mistrust.
Impact of Multilingual Presentation	Multilingual blending, overlaps, or creative interplay heightens emotional engagement; feels cosmopolitan and inclusive.	Separate, clearly distinguished scripts preserve clarity and cultural respect, fostering a sense of belonging.
Emotional Triggers	Feels joy and connection when design invites interpretation, surprise, or visual storytelling through scripts.	Feels valued and connected when design honors script traditions, legibility, and respectful representation.
Emotional Risks	Overly functional or rigid script styles can feel emotionally flat and uninspiring.	Overly abstract or symbolic script styles can feel alienating or culturally disconnected.

Core Insight:

- Younger audiences (18–25) are emotionally activated by creativity, reinterpretation, and layered meaning.
- Older audiences (46+) are emotionally activated by familiarity, clarity, and cultural fidelity.

CONCLUSION

Future Scope:

- Under exploration of emotional disengagement in older audiences.
- Insufficient integration of cultural relatability with typography studies.

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- Gap in practical design frameworks for multi-age audiences.

- Neglect of the “emotional language vs. technical language” divide.

RECCOMENDATIONS

- Multi-Script Integration- Arrange both scripts side-by-side, intertwined, or stacked, so they are visually connected and seen as one design rather than separate elements.
- Typographic Emotion Mapping- Use type anatomy (stroke thickness, curvature, texture) to evoke feelings — this works even if the script is unfamiliar. Example: Loose letter spacing for calmness, condensed forms for urgency, high contrast strokes for drama.
- Color as Emotional Glue- Maintain a consistent color-emotion mapping across scripts (e.g., warm reds for energy, cool blues for calm) so emotional cues transcend language.
- Accessibility Considerations- Ensure at least one script is high-contrast and easy to read for older viewers. Avoid overly decorative type in the clarity layer; keep the expressive type for the emotional layer.
- Use textured typography to give script-based designs a tactile, layered feel that appeals to younger audiences’ love for depth while providing visual richness that older audiences can immediately perceive without needing abstract interpretation.
- Integrate subtle iconography within letterforms, where familiar cultural symbols or shapes are embedded into the strokes of the script, making abstract text more relatable and recognisable across all age groups.
- Employ interpretive typographic storytelling, where the form of the word itself visually narrates the theme—allowing abstraction

to exist alongside recognisable imagery so every age group finds a point of connection.